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Deterministic Evacuation Mapping: An Automated QGIS Plugin for Building-Level Analysis

Gaurav Khairnar[1,2], **RS Mahendra**[1], **Ch Patanjali**[1], **TNC Kartik**[1], **Sudheer Joseph**[1], **and TM Balakrishnan Nair**[1]

1 Indian National Centre for Ocean Information Services, Ministry of Earth Sciences, Hyderabad, Telangana, India **2** Department of Climate Change, Indian Institute of Technology, Hyderabad, Telangana, India

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Software

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Summery

Build_Short_Evac_Time is an open-source QGIS plugin that supports deterministic **building-level evacuation planning** for flood and inundation hazards. It automatically identifies buildings located within an inundation zone and computes **shortest evacuation routes** from those at-risk buildings to nearest safe shelters using open street map road network data. The plugin aims to assist GIS users and disaster risk planners in generating rapid evacuation path outputs with minimal input requirements

Statement of need

Evacuation planning in flood and inundation hazard-prone areas (e.g., tsunami, storm surge and coastal flooding) requires tools that can efficiently compute and visualize evacuation routes from individual buildings toward safe locations. Although existing GIS workflows can perform network-based analysis and QGIS provides general spatial and network analysis capabilities, implementing a complete workflow for building-level evacuation routing typically requires multiple manual steps or custom scripting. There is a lack of easy-to-use QGIS plugins tailored specifically for at-risk building identification and shortest time evacuation assessment based on walk-time in inundation scenarios.

Build_Short_Evac_Time a QGIS plugin addresses this gap by integrating inundation-based buildings at risk selection with time-based network routing in a single interface. This plugin provides an open-source implementation of that framework within QGIS, enabling reproducible and operational evacuation planning. The plugin computes evacuation time rather than only distance and assigns each building to the nearest shelter that can be reached in the shortest time.

This tool supports disaster risk planners, local goverment, researchers and GIS practitioners in generating reproducible and terrain-aware evacuation analyses within an open-source GIS environment.

Methodology

The plugin follows an automated, deterministic workflow that identifies at-risk buildings by overlaying building footprints with the inundation extent. Safe shelters are then identified, and the OpenStreetMap pedestrian network is used to calculate the shortest evacuation paths from buildings to shelters. Where a DEM is provided, terrain slope is incorporated using Tobler's Hiking Function to estimate walking time. The resulting evacuation time is stored as

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an attribute and buildings can be classified according to evacuation time thresholds for further analysis and visualization. The resulting classified buildings and evacuation routes are generated as QGIS output layers. The theoretical framework of the tsunami walk-time modelling approach is described in Khairnar, G. et al. A geospatial framework for tsunami evacuation walk-time mapping. Spat. Inf. Res. 34, 33 (2026). https://doi.org/10.1007/s41324-026-00680-1.

Functionality

The plugin operates within the QGIS environment and provides an integrated workflow for building-level evacuation time analysis. Its main functionality includes:

- **Input layers**:
  - Building footprints (Polygon vector layer in .shp or .geojson format)
  - Inundation or hazard extent polygon (Polygon vector layer in .shp or .geojson format)
  - Shelter locations (Point vector layer in .shp or .geojson format)
  - Optional Digital Elevation Model (Raster layer in preferably in .tiff format) for slope-based walking speed adjustment
- **At-risk building identification**: Buildings intersecting the inundation polygon are automatically detected and selected for evacuation analysis.
- **Time-based network routing**: For each at-risk building, the plugin computes evacuation routes to available shelters using the OSM road network. Evacuation time is calculated based on walking speed assumptions.
- **Minimum-time shelter allocation**: Each building is assigned to the shelter that can be reached in the shortest evacuation time rather than shortest distance.
- **Optional terrain-adjusted walking speed**: When a Digital Elevation Model (DEM) is provided, slope values along the evacuation route are used to adjust walking speed, allowing terrain-dependent evacuation time estimation.
- **Output generation**: After successful execution, 2 output layers will generate, first is buildings which are at risk and second is evacuation routes. Each building is assigned to the nearest evacuation shelter and that shelter's ID and evacuation time is added in that building's attribute. Buildings are classified according to evacuation time categories for further spatial analysis and visualization.

Availability

The source code for Building-level Shortest Evacuation Time is openly available at: https://github.com/gauravbkhairnar/Build_Short_Evac_Time_QGIS_Plugin

The plugin is distributed under the MIT License. It is designed to operate within the QGIS environment and can be installed through the QGIS Plugin Manager or manually from the repository. The project documentation, installation instructions and example usage are provided in the repository README file.

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